

Mrs Singh's DAY OUT

The prime minister's wife comes into her own, combining elegance with homespun wisdom and social causes to add substance to her active role as First Lady

| By Priya Sahgal |

Would you tell the woman sitting next to you at an official heads of state dinner that she has lipstick on her teeth, especially if she is France's First Lady Carla Bruni-Sarkozy? Most would let status quo remain and, for a brief while, so did Gursharan Kaur. But only for a brief while. As far as Manmohan Singh's rather pragmatic wife is concerned, straight talk scores over small talk any day.

It has been a while since the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) had a woman's touch and for the first time since Independence that there is an active First Lady in residence. While Rajiv Gandhi was prime minister, a shy Sonia rarely ventured out on her own. Much later in 1997, during I.K. Gujral's brief tenure, his wife Sheila stepped out from Race Course Road and toured the capital's poetry circuit. But Gursharan is more adventurous: from a 3.5-km walk around Lutyens' Delhi in support of breast cancer

patients to dinner with the Obamas at the White House. When the statuesque Michelle towered over her during a photoshoot, Gursharan joked that they must look strange standing together. A laughing Michelle offered to kick off her heels.

That's the thing about Gursharan. She may not be the main plot, but somehow she becomes a vibrant part of the script. It's also the part that reminds you of your own mother. Even before she became a familiar face in Delhi's Punjabi circuit, one got a glimpse of her no-nonsense kitchen

table talk in the then finance minister's budget speeches. Manmohan often referred to his own "finance minister" whenever he announced a household budget perk such as export duty exemptions on tiffin boxes. Later, when her economist husband became prime minister, her first public words to him were not to increase the price of cooking gas. It does not matter that her husband is an Oxbridge graduate and the country's most renowned economist. Or that she herself passed school-level economics with the help of *kunjis* (guide books). What she was offering was simple homespun wisdom gained over 52 years of balancing the budget most important to Manmohan—that of his own home.

Daughter Daman says with a smile, "She is constantly giving him advice, especially on prices. He listens to everything she says. What he does is another matter." Yet, six months later when Manmohan's Government was criticised for hiking the price of petroleum products in November 2004, she rushed to his support, extolling the virtues of sacrifice. She told the media, "I or any other housewife

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